

Where He Lived and Died

The man had lived alone in the crumbling, dust-coated house for as long as he could remember. It was the same house he'd grown up in, though now it was a relic of the 1980s with the crumb-covered shag carpeting and the fake wood panels that are slowly peeling from their position on the walls. He often told himself he'd get around to fixing it up. When he won the lottery, maybe? Or when he "felt like it." But that day never came. Instead, he just stayed. Day after day, night after night, wandering aimlessly from room to room, dreaming about other lives he never lived. He'd once thought about moving somewhere else to make a name for himself, somewhere exciting, like California or New York, but that never happened.

He didn't have a job. He didn't need one, or so he always claimed. There was some money left to him after his parents died. It wasn't a lot, but it was enough to survive. Enough that he could avoid working and claim he "lived easy." He didn't even need to go out for groceries anymore. He had them delivered once a week, usually canned goods and frozen dinners. Fresh food didn't last long in the dingy kitchen. The old, sagging armchair in his living room had molded to his shape, and he spent hours there, day after day. The television was always on, though he barely watched it. Reruns of the same crime dramas filled the screen—detectives and criminals repeating the same storylines over and over. It was just noise, something to fill the silence.

One day, seemingly exactly as the last, the man sat there, staring at the screen, when his heart began to suddenly pound. He gasped and tried to stand up, but his legs gave out beneath him. He fell hard, crashing through the cedar wood coffee table, dust clouding around him. He lay there on the floor, as a sharp, stabbing pain spread from his chest through his arms and jaw. His mind raced, sensing that something was very wrong.

As he lay there, his mind wandered back over his life. But it wasn't full of the things he had done. No, it was full of missed opportunities and things he'd once dismissed as pointless risks. He thought about the person he never asked out. Would they have said yes? He thought about the kids he never had. Would they have looked like him or like their other parents, whoever they might have been? He thought about the friends he never made. Would they have been there to save him? He remembered the times he almost attended his local bingo, but never followed through. There had been chances for these things, he assumed, but he never took them. Always telling himself he'd wait for the right moment, but that moment never came.

Maybe it was fear, or maybe it was just laziness. He also thought about how he never took care of himself physically. His diet had always been a disaster—cheap fast food, processed snacks, whatever required the least effort. He never exercised, never walking further than his front door during adulthood. And now, here he lay, on the floor, wheezing out his next breath. He began to feel cold all over yet sweat dripped down his body. The pain felt like punishment, but for what? He figured maybe if he'd made better choices, he wouldn't be dying alone.

He didn't want this, though. He'd never felt sorry for himself before, and he wasn't about to start. Instead, he felt a simmering resentment rise in him. Why should this be his fault? It wasn't like anyone had ever helped him. His parents never encouraged him to go out more or move out when he reached adulthood. They just left him the house and the money. They said it was because they "trusted him to make his own choices," but he suspected it was because they simply didn't care. What else was he supposed to do? He stayed because that was what was easy. They didn't prepare him for anything else. Their parenting choices had trapped him in this house, this life. Forever.

He thought about the people who had passed through his life. Neighbors, classmates, even some he'd been romantically interested in. Why did none of them try to keep in touch? It couldn't be his fault that none of them cared enough to call or visit. If they had really wanted him around, wouldn't they have tried harder? He convinced himself he was the victim of everyone else's neglect. How could he have made friends or created a family of his own if no one bothered to reach out to him?

The pain in his chest worsened, and he felt as though he was suffocating, but his mind kept going. The flood of old grudges and resentments wouldn't let him die in peace. He kept thinking about all the things that hadn't gone right in his life. It wasn't fair. Why did it have to end like this? He cursed every one of them. The parents who forced him to live as an unloved child forever, the friends who left him, the potential lovers who never gave him a chance. He wasn't the one to blame.

As he lay there, his vision fading and his breath growing choppier, he felt nothing but anger. Anger at the world, at his parents, at everyone who'd let him live like this, never bothering to help or push him toward something better. He'd been cheated. He never had a fair chance to live. And just before his heart stopped pumping and everything went dark, one final thought crossed the man's mind: It's everyone else's fault.

And then, there was nothing. Just a man on the floor.